STEADFAST MEN

Lesson 23 · Give Your Son a Hill

Transcript · Wes Hart

Hey. Come on and sit if you're still standing. Good to see you. Uh, the day was already full before you got here. You came in anyway. I'm glad for that. Last lesson we stayed with a boy's name. The sentence a father puts on him. What he starts to answer to Uh, when the house goes quiet. I tried mine. Had it ready before the driveway. He met me at the door with a cup. Said the milk was gone. I told him a man can handle a little lack. He looked in the cup. He said, so this is water. So the blessing stayed in the truck. In this lesson that name needs somewhere to stand. If you haven't caught my name yet, I'm Wes. Glad you took a chair. Here's the thing. A name without a hill is only a compliment.

You can— you can call a boy capable over breakfast, and mean it. If he never climbs something that proves the word, Uh, it stays kind. Kind is not the same as true in his hands. The name gets true in him when the hard thing matches the word. Uh, a lot of boys are not short on fight. They're short on ground. Somebody has to hand them a piece of it and then stay low enough to let them climb. Pick the right hill. Stay on the step. Say the right thing when he comes down. That's the whole job in one breath. We'll walk it slow. The step is not a mood. It's a place. Close enough that he can see you. Far enough that the work stays his. Uh, most of us got one or the other. A soft house, Uh, or a man who took the work back. I have been both. I can talk about the step without pretending I enjoy it. Uh, if there is no son in your house, don't drift. A nephew. The boy you coach. The kid who hangs around after. He has ears, and he has never been handed ground. You are on this page with the rest of us.

These four marks are the sentence we keep coming back to. Same words you've heard in this room. I have not improved them. A steadfast man stops waiting, picks up the weight, goes first, and works for God's pay, not the room's.

I'm not rebuilding all four. Here they stand on the ground. Uh, stop waiting. On this, passivity can look like a busy man. You take his hill because you're faster, everybody exhales, Uh, and he learns his hands were optional. Pick up the weight. The size of the hill is yours to pick. Too small is pretend. Too big is a crush. The next piece is the one you owe him. Go first. Courage, here, is staying put when every part of you wants the tool. Work for God's pay. Not the room's. The peace of a boy who never struggles is a thin peace. The Father sees the man who kept his hands open. Uh, I know the pull. Empty hands feel like you walked off. They are not a walk-off. They are the work. Here's what I want plain. Uh, boys do not turn into men because the house was soft enough. A little past him, with a man in sight who is slow to rescue, that is how the word you spoke gets a body. Pad every hard thing and the strength you hoped to save never shows up. I mean, love can do that. Love with no climb leaves him unseen. He will go find ground. The ground he finds on his own runs worse, or he quits looking and lives in his room with the door almost shut, because the world looks like a slope and the bottom of it is empty. Uh, stay with me. The answer is not a harder speech. The answer is a real hill, and a father who can sit still.

Let me tell you what counts, because a boy can tell the other kind. Uh, five tests. You don't need a fancier list. Real is the first. Somebody besides him needs the thing done. If it fails, the house feels it, or a neighbor feels it, or a person he loves feels it. He can— he can tell a made-up task before he picks up the tool. You built it so he would grow. Uh, he did not ask for it, nobody else needs it, and he will not respect it. A little past him is the second. Past what he pulled off yesterday. Short of a weight that would flatten him. If he can do it half asleep, it is not a hill. If it would break him, he decides hills are for other people, and he steps around the next one. The third is risk you already measured. He may fail. He may pick up a small hurt. Uh, he may come down with the thing still open and the day still honest. You are not rolling dice with his life. You looked at the real danger first, and that part is already off the table. Uh, the fourth is the ending. He does not get to stop at I tried. Either it is finished, or he can say the next move out loud, and then go do it. That is a man owning a result. I tried, forever, is a boy waiting to be excused. And a name after it. That's the fifth. Uh, he comes down, win or mess, and you speak. The word you gave him before the climb starts to fit the boy in front of you, or you tell the truth about what still needs work, without turning the mess into his name. Five, if you want them in your pocket. Real. A little past him. Risk you already measured. An ending he owns. Your voice when he comes down. Miss one, and you handed him dirt with a nice story on it.

The hill changes as he does. The five tests don't. Uh, small years. A job the house actually feels. You're loading the car. The cooler is his, both hands, from the kitchen to the trunk. It bangs his shin. You want it. You don't take it at the curb. You tell him the lunch is in the back because he carried it. School years, he needs ownership, not a string of favors. The mail is his. Rain included. If it sits out and a bill curls up wet, Uh, that outcome is his. You don't sneak down the walk and spare him the mistake. Uh, as he stretches toward his teens, put him under a man who is not you. A neighbor. A boss with no interest in your feelings. That man can look at the work and say it isn't done. You do not walk over and make it pretty. And at least one climb he takes while you are in sight and you are not coming. You know, high school is where it gets expensive. A shift he can lose. Money he can spend wrong. He blows the first check on something foolish. You do not refill the wallet Uh, to protect him from the sting. A decision you do not overrule just because you can see the ditch. Then he is out on his own. The hill is the life he is building. Your part gets smaller. Answer when he calls. Don't drive over and take the tool out of his hand. Uh, if you only keep one of these, keep the man who is not you. Your praise is too easy for him to bargain with. Don't skip to the later years and call the early ones a warm-up. The man he is at twenty Uh, was built on the cooler, the wet mail, and the wallet you left alone. Skip those, and you are hoping a stranger will form him on a schedule you don't control.

Put this in your ear. It's in your workbook. First Thessalonians two, verses eleven and twelve. For you know that we dealt with each of you as a father deals with his own children, encouraging, comforting and urging you to live lives worthy of God, who calls you into his kingdom and glory.

Encouraging. Comforting. Urging. A father does all three, and they are not the same move. Uh, encourage is the true word. Tied to a thing he actually did. Not a cloud of praise. Uh, not a mood you were in. You saw the work. You name what you saw. Comfort is presence. He can look back and you are still there. Comfort is not you taking the hill because his face got tight. A boy who is safe, and watched, learns he can do the thing. A boy who is rescued while he is safe learns he needs a rescue. Urge is the hill itself, aimed somewhere. Paul does not say urge them to be busy. He says urge them

to live a life worthy of the God who called them. Uh, if all you hand him is a harder chore, he can nod, sweat a little, and never be aimed at anything. Sweat is not the same as a worthy life. The hill has to matter, and the mattering has to point past your driveway. I mean, toughness with no God in it just makes a harder boy. We are not collecting harder boys. We are raising sons who can carry a real thing and still know who they belong to. Say it plainer, in case the verse went by too clean. Encourage means you tell the truth Uh, about what you watched him do. Comfort means you stay in sight and you don't grab it. Urge means the hill is aimed at a life God would call worthy, not at your need to see him busy. Stay with that order. Encourage. Comfort. Urge. The word, the man who stayed, and the ground under his feet.

There are two ways to leave him with no hill, and both of them feel like love. Uh, you protect him from every hard thing. Or you do the hard thing yourself. Protect him long enough and he starves. The muscle you meant to save Uh, never gets used, and then you are surprised when a small weight drops him. Do it yourself, and he never climbs. You were faster. The job looks better. He was standing right there, holding nothing. I have— I have done the second one more times than I want in this room. Closet door stuck. I told him it was his. Go find a screwdriver. While he was in the junk drawer, I popped the pin, Uh, shaved the high spot, and had it swinging. He came back proud he'd found the tool. I said, already handled it. He said thanks. I took the thanks. What he learned was simple. Dad finishes. Boys look for screwdrivers. I thought— I thought faster was faithful. Faithful would have been the step. How many of you have finished a job your boy started, because you were faster, and you called it help? Go ahead. Let me see them. Yeah. Mine was up. I tried to make it look like a stretch. Your boy did not need a faster man. Uh, he needed the man to stay off the work. Look at your hands a second. If those hands close every hard thing in the house, his hands stay smooth, and yours stay sure, and sure starts to look like love. It isn't. Not on his hill. Sitting there with empty hands will feel like neglect the first dozen times. It is training. His mother may feel the wait sooner than you do. Lead that talk. Lead it kindly. You are on the same side of the boy.

Some of what we hand them is just dirt. It looks like a hill from the driveway. It doesn't climb. Uh, one version is the sport as his whole life. I could tell you the order he batted. I could not tell you the last hard thing the house had trusted him with. There wasn't one. If the game went well, I felt like a father. A game can get rained out. A boy still has to be formed on a quiet day, when nobody is keeping score. Another version is rules with no cause under them. I got serious about standards. Made a list. Typed it clean. I laminated it. Uh, hung it where the shine could preach. He could recite every line. I asked him what it was for. He said, so I don't get in trouble. That's a fence around an empty lot. He knew what to avoid. He did not know what he was for. Uh, another version is a job that never ends because it was never his. You start a shelf and leave him the sanding, so he'll learn. He knows whose project it is. Your name is on the idea. His name is on the dust. Uh, no finish line. No coming down. Just a nod when you walk by. Or you make the boy the whole assignment. You sit him down to talk about his attitude. He nods at the right times. Nobody at that table needs a thing from him but a better mood. He was the project. Boys learn to perform a project like that. Or you hand him nothing. Rides, snacks, a soft house, and no ground at all. You know, that one feels like kindness. It is an empty bottom. Uh, he will go looking. A stunt somebody talks him into filming. A crew that lets him in if he takes what isn't his. Or the door almost shut, for a long time, because nobody ever showed him he could climb a real thing.

Let me tell you about a man I'll call Keith. Good father. Uh, shows up. His boy was getting his height, old enough to want money that wasn't allowance. Keith's brother kept an old pop-up camper under a tree, crooked, and a reunion was coming. Uh, the hitch light was dead. Keith told his boy the light was his. If it doesn't blink, we don't pull it. Uh, the boy had the little manual open on his phone. He was tracing the wire the slow way, the way a man learns. Keith watched. Then his knee was in the gravel and the strippers were in his hand, because he could smell the short and the afternoon was leaving. The boy held the light. Shifted his feet. Didn't argue. The brother walked up, saw Keith under the tongue of the trailer, and said, good, you got it. Uh, he thanked the wrong pair of hands. On the drive, the boy said, you like it better when I hold the light. Keith told me he turned the radio up. He felt it anyway, sitting there like a stone on his chest. He almost— he almost argued. He didn't. Said he was afraid if he opened his mouth he'd make a speech and bury the sentence. Next day the boy's bike was flat. They weren't late for anything. Keith sat on the tailgate. Hands under his legs. The boy pinched the tube in the bead Uh, and had to start over with a couple of spoons from the kitchen. A neighbor slowed his car like he might stop and save the morning. Keith shook his head and stayed where he was. The tire held. The boy pressed it, didn't trust it, pressed it again. Keith said, you found where it pinched, and you started over. That tire is yours. I'm glad I stayed off it. Uh, the boy rode to the stop sign and back. Didn't say much. The ride was the proof.

The step is the hard obedience. Staying there is the part that burns. You already know you are faster, right? Uh, watch him struggle anyway. A miss and a do-over are allowed. Pull him off while he is still safe, and you teach him to wait for you. Let the cost stay small while it still fits in a day. He loses a shift because the alarm never got set. That sting is a mercy. Uh, leave the habit alone, and the cost shows up where you cannot catch it. Uh, when he comes down, ask. Not a speech while the sweat is still on him. You ask— you ask what happened. What he learned. What changes before he tries again. Then quiet, so his own answer has room. Then name what you saw. You stayed with it. I watched the work hold. No true word at the bottom, and he won't know what to keep. Next time, raise it a little. Not a cliff. Uh, a little past the last one. Colossians three, verse twenty-one. Fathers, do not embitter your children, or they will become discouraged.

A cliff on the first try does that. So does your old dream, dressed up as his future. He is not the fix for your regret. So does the easy rescue. You replace what he broke before he has to face the man. You apologize for him while he is still in the car. He hears one thing. This is past you. Uh, shame does the rest. You retell the miss until it's a good story. He will route around anything he might fail where people can see. Don't— don't build the first hill like a cliff, and don't enjoy the fall. I made myself sit on a cooler once. Hands under my legs. A chain kept hopping off a bike. Uh, my wife stepped into the driveway, looked at my face, and asked who had made me mad. I said, the bike. I was trying to stay seated. It had climbed up into my face. If you grew up under shame, go slow. Don't settle that score through your son. Kind, and not a tyrant. Uh, if you have been leaving the step for years, he is not used up. A late hill still counts. Hand one, and stay.

Hear the chair you are actually in. Uh, if your boy is in his first year, the three a.m. feed is not dirt. It is also not the whole hill. Uh, show up tired. Don't make him pay for your sleep with a short temper you call standards. The yard you keep not finishing is not manhood by itself. Name which one you have been calling the hill. If the marriage came apart, Uh, don't sand the hard thing off the visit so he will

like your place. It is not ground. He needs— he needs one job that is his when he is with you, left unfinished on purpose, so the work is why he comes back. Daughters at home, and no son. They are owed real work. Don't skip them. If a boy is in reach, a nephew, the kid who stays late, this page is still yours. Young, and the house is still just you. You already stand for something, Uh, or you don't. A wife later will not hand you this skill. If the job is going well, a calm boy can still be an untested one.

Older men. A grown son still needs a place to stand, and he needs your hands off it. Never had a son? You are not decoration in this room. Let me tell you about a man I'll call Silas. Uh, no kids of his own. A boy across the breezeway. Mother on a late shift. Father not in the picture. The scooter brake rubbed, and the boy was mostly kicking it. Silas told the mother first. Uh, then he set a wrench on the open walk, where any neighbor could see, and he took the stair. He said, that brake is yours. I'm here if you get stuck. The boy's hand slipped. Grease under the nail. Silas stood up. Sat back down. You stay— you stay where people can see you. Not a closed room. Not a secret kindness. The brake eased. Silas said it so the walk could hear, you stayed after it slipped. Uh, it stops now because you didn't give it back. Grandfathers. You may have the patience a tired father has not grown yet. Don't spend that patience by being faster. Point him at one real job. Sit. Say the true thing while it is still warm.

Let me land it. A name without a hill is only a compliment.

You can bless a boy and still leave the word with nowhere to live. Pick the right hill. Then stay on the step until he comes down, and tell him what you saw. What I hope— what I hope you walk out with is not a mood about fathering. It's one hill you have actually named, and a decision to keep your hands off it until he comes down. If there is no son, Uh, it's one boy, one real job, and you where he can see you. A steadfast man stops waiting, picks up the weight, goes first, and works for God's pay, not the room's.

Keep that line close. Here it means you don't climb it for him, you don't hide him from it, and you trust God with the slow work. Your workbook is where this gets particular. Uh, in a minute you'll sit at the tables and work this part together. Get the questions in your ear. Does he have a hill right now? Something real, a little past him, with an ending he owns. If he doesn't, Uh, which miss is it? Have you been protecting him, or have you been doing it yourself? What hill will you hand him, and will you stay on the step? Say it out loud at the table. A son in the house, or a younger man in reach. Both of you own the page. If the boy is brand new, say it straight. The night feed, or the yard you keep not finishing. Which one have you been calling the hill? Tell a brother the hill, Uh, and how hard it was to stay put. Ask what hills his father gave him. Ask what he is giving now. No son? You still tell one man. Name the younger man out loud. Carry this, and write it where you'll see it. A name without a hill is only a compliment. Pick the right hill. Stay on the step. Say the right thing when he comes down. Then go to your tables. Work this part of the workbook together.